Though Buddhism faced challenges from Saiva and Vaishnava sects from the Pallava period onwards. One of the exceptions was Nagapattinam, which was supported by Chola kings, not for religious but for political reasons. Chudamani Vihara of Nagapattinam was constructed by the Srivijaya king with the patronage of Rajaraja Chola. This vihara has been since destroyed. The Tamil epic, *Manimekalai,* written by Kulavanigan Sithalai Sattanar, is considered a typical representation of Tamil Buddhism. Sattanar indigenised Buddhism into Tamil Buddhism by communicating a large set of Buddhist terms in Tamil, as translations from Sanskrit and Pali.

There is a record about a Buddhist monk named Vajrabodhi, who was skilled in tantric rituals, but this monk left the Pallava court for China. Mahendravarman's *Mattavilāsa Prahasana* describes Buddhism as a religion in decay.

In the field of education, Buddhist *Sanghas* and *Viharas* served as centres of education. Students from various parts of the world came here to receive education. Nalanda, Taxila and Vikramshila gained reputation as great educational centres. They were originally Buddhist Viharas. Students from Tibet and China were influenced by Buddhism and they took effective steps to spread Buddhism.

A Vihara in Sanskrit means 'dwelling' or 'house'. Originally, viharas were dwelling places used by wandering monks during the rainy season. Later they transformed into centres of learning through the donations of wealthy lay Buddhists. Royal patronage allowed pre-Muslim India to become a land of many viharas that imparted university education and were treasure troves of sacred texts. Many viharas, such as Nalanda were world famous.

Viharas



Buddhist Vihara of Nalanda in ruins

Excavations of Buddhist Vihara and a temple at Kaveripoompattinam and hundreds of stone and bronze sculptures by ASI from over 125 sites have proved the spread of the religion in the state. A 1.03 metre Buddha statue in *'padmasana'* pose in remote Tirunattiyattankudi village in Tiruvarur district was unearthed when digging a tank in a field.



Buddha in '*padmasana*' pose

3. Ajivika Philosophy

The Ajivikas believed in the doctrine of karma, transmigration of the soul and

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